MADHYA PRADESH

Taking a Dip in Troubled Waters

As CM Yadav prepares to build grand mela infra in hometown Ujjain, farmers are up in arms against the proposal to pool land

By **Rahul Noronha**





NO CAN DO Farmers protest against the Simhastha land acquisition bid in Ujjain; (inset) CM Mohan Yadav

UJJAIN, THE HOME BASE OF MADHYA PRADESH CM Mohan Yadav, is in ferment. Reason: a move to pool agricultural land to build permanent infrastructure for the Simhastha Mela in 2028, expected to be one of the state's biggest religious congregations ever. The farmers from whom land is to be acquired are up in arms. And not only the Congress, even the RSS-affiliated Bharatiya Kisan Sangh (BKS) is pitted against the BJP government on the issue. How does a religious issue polarise the field in such odd ways? Due to the terms under which land is to be acquired.

MP has a 'land pooling' policy under which farmers can cede half their agri holdings to the state for residential projects. Under its terms, 35 per cent would go for civil infrastructure, and 15 per cent for housing—the hook was that the 50 per cent the farmer retained would now fetch higher returns because of the surrounding development. This framework is now extended to private developers. But that's not at issue here. The present plan involves only the Ujjain Development Authority (UDA).

The Simhastha is a 12-yearly mela akin to the Kumbh, centred around the revered Mahakaleshwar jyotirlinga. Lakhs of pilgrims descend on Ujjain and take a holy dip in the Shipra river. The idea for developing permanent mela infrastructure arose because of past experience. Reports had detailed how, during the last edition of Simhastha in 2016, sewage, water supply and roads had become a huge mess.

To obviate that, the plan is to have road, electricity and sewage infrastructure over 2,300 hectares of the 3,100-ha designated mela area. Of this, 1,900 has to be acquired—only 300 has materialised. Trouble is, the rest of the farmers are spooked by the fact that, unlike for residential projects where land value appreciation is immense, the mela proposal allows only schools, colleges and hospitals to be built over the remaining land. The 1,700 affected farmers fear this would strip the land of its value, leaving them with nothing.

The Congress was quick to echo their angst. But worryingly for the government, in mid-September, BKS general secretary Mohini Mohan Mishra, too, led a protest. With the Simhastha expected to see around 300 million pilgrims, it's a prestige issue for the CM, given his Ujjain connection and the high cachet in the party for pilgrim tourism. After the creation of Ujjain's Mahakal Lok Corridor in 2022, the jyotirlinga's footfalls have soared from 5,000 to around a lakh daily. Yadav wishes to leave his own stamp on his city. Last heard, hectic talks were on. ■

Takeaways

- **Farmers in Ujjain up in arms against move to 'pool' their land for 2028 Simhastha mela**
- **CM Yadav wants permanent infra around 3,100-hectare area to ensure smooth mela**
- **Unlike for urban projects, farmers fear giving up land portions for the project will slash value of farmland**